Vikrant Massey is 37 but looks like he could play a college student in his next. Seated in a Netflix studio, he laughs when asked about the secret of his youthful appearance. "It could be my face wash!" he jokes. "But the honest answer is my skin needed some fresh air, so I shaved." There could be more beneath the surface though, the simple fact that it's just a good time to be Vikrant Massey. Nearly a year since its release, the Massey-led *12th Fail* is still cited as the feel-good film that proved it doesn't always take a spectacle to win over audiences in cinemas. Then there's *Phir Aayi Hasseen Dillruba*, a sequel to the popular romantic thriller, which trended at #1 on Netflix for weeks. And now Massey is excited for people to see him as a serial killer—that too of children—in *Sector 36*, also a Netflix release.

So what's with the good guy gone bad act? "I want to break the mould and here's an opportunity to play a part I've never played before," he says. "But the biggest reason I associated [with the film] was the intent of the story and why it needs to be told." Inspired by true events which going by the trailer seem reminiscent of the killings in Nithari in Uttar Pradesh's Noida, the thriller follows Deepak Dobriyal's police officer trying to nab Massey's Prem Singh. Massey found himself reading up on serial killers to prepare for the part. Singh's ordinariness, his ability to get lost in the crowd, is what made him fascinating to play, he notes. "Social neglect and class disparity come into play," he says. "But in no way are we trying to glorify or justify his actions."

Given the fillip that *12th Fail* has given to Massey's career, on paper *Sector 36* is a risk. Why take a detour when you are sailing along smoothly? He admits there have been some who've questioned his judgement when it came to playing a part that's raven black. "I am a little cuckoo in my head," says Massey. "There were the peripherals, noises... but I really can't be thinking of these things. Everything is so transient in nature, success and failure both. *Sector 36* is an opportunity for me to contribute as a storyteller to reflect on the times we are living in. There's nothing bigger than that, not my last film and public perception."

Even before Massey hit a high both critically and at the box office with *12th Fail*, he had been impressing. *A Death in the Gunj*, *Mirzapur*, *Chhapaak*... They all show an actor cleverly shuttling between the worlds of independent and commercial cinema. For Massey, that's just him listening to his "inner locus". "I have always relied on whatever my driving force within is," he says. It also helps him with his larger objective. Adds Massey, "My biggest aspiration has always been to have a certain sense of archival value with my films. I want to be worth people's time



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